Saving for a First Home Takes Much Longer Now

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Buying a first home has gotten much harder for many families in the United States, a new **report** says.

The Center for Responsible Lending studied how long **renters** need to save money to buy a small starter home. Buyers must pay a first chunk of money, called a **down payment**, plus extra **fees**.

The group found that a typical renter family now needs about 16 years to save enough. That is twice as long as in 2019. Teachers, nurses, firefighters and police officers need about 10 to 13 years.

Why? Homes cost more. Food, gas and rent cost more too. But many families' pay has not gone up as fast.

The wait is different in each city. It is 11 years in Houston and 24 years in Los Angeles.

The group wants more help for first-time buyers and more small, cheaper homes. Still, many young adults say they hope to own a home one day.

Word Treasure

down payment -- A down payment is the first chunk of money paid when buying a home.

renters -- Renters are people who pay money to live in a home owned by someone else.

report -- A report is a document that shares facts someone found by studying a topic.

fees -- Fees are amounts of money charged for a service.

Background you need

Most families who buy a home borrow money from a bank and pay part of the price first, called a down payment.

When prices for homes, food and rent go up faster than pay, it takes longer to save money.

A starter home is a smaller, cheaper home that people often buy first.

Break it down

WHO: The Center for Responsible Lending and renter families in the United States
WHAT: A report found it now takes about 16 years for a typical renter family to save for a first home
WHERE: Cities across the United States, from Houston to Los Angeles
WHY: Homes, food, gas and rent cost more, but many families' pay has not risen as fast

Why it matters

Where your family can afford to live affects your home, school and neighborhood.

Test what you remember

1. How many years does a typical renter family need to save for a first home?

- (A) About 5
- (B) About 2
- (C) About 16
- (D) About 50

2. How does that compare with 2019?

- (A) It is ten times longer
- (B) It is shorter
- (C) It is the same
- (D) It is twice as long

3. Which city has the shortest wait in the story?

- (A) Los Angeles
- (B) Paris
- (C) Houston
- (D) Miami

4. How long do teachers and nurses need to save?

- (A) About 1 year
- (B) About 30 years
- (C) About 10 to 13 years
- (D) About 3 months

5. What is one reason saving takes longer?

- (A) Banks closed
- (B) Homes and rent cost more
- (C) People stopped working
- (D) Houses got bigger

6. What does the group want more of?

- (A) Bigger yards
- (B) Small, cheaper homes
- (C) More parking
- (D) Taller buildings

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Center for Responsible Lending: Wants more help for first-time buyers and more small, cheaper homes.

2. Young adults: Still hope to own a home one day.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):